

but for which it is not possible to completely figure out the properties and produce precise calculations.

Mediocristan: the province dominated by the mediocre, with few extreme successes or failures. No single observation can meaningfully affect the aggregate. The bell curve is grounded in Mediocristan. There is a qualitative difference between Gaussians and scalable laws, much like gas and water.

Narrative discipline: the discipline that consists in fitting a convincing and well-sounding story to the past. Opposed to experimental discipline.

Narrative fallacy: our need to fit a story or pattern to a series of connected or disconnected facts. The statistical application is data mining.

Nerd knowledge: the belief that what cannot be Platonized and studied does not exist at all, or is not worth considering. There even exists a form of skepticism practiced by the nerd.

Platonic fold: the place where our Platonic representation enters into contact with reality and you can see the side effects of models.

Platonicity: the focus on those pure, well-defined, and easily discernible objects like triangles, or more social notions like friendship or love, at the cost of ignoring those objects of seemingly messier and less tractable structures.

Probability distribution: the model used to calculate the odds of different events, how they are “distributed.” When we say that an event is distributed according to the bell curve, we mean that the Gaussian bell curve can help provide probabilities of various occurrences.

Problem of induction: the logical-philosophical extension of the Black Swan problem.

Randomness as incomplete information: simply, what I cannot guess is random because my knowledge about the causes is incomplete, not necessarily because the process has truly unpredictable properties.

Retrospective distortion: examining past events without adjusting for the forward passage of time. It leads to the illusion of posterior predictability.

Reverse-engineering problem: It is easier to predict how an ice cube would melt into a puddle than, looking at a puddle, to guess the shape of the ice cube that may have caused it. This “inverse problem” makes narrative disciplines and accounts (such as histories) suspicious.